than amply validated by geopolitical developments. There have been other trade and economic negotiations that have each presented their dilemmas. Our positions have been guided by clear-eyed calculation and sound gut instincts about social consequences.

Yet, it would be a gross mistake to project the Modi government in protectionist terms. On the contrary, rarely in our history have more strenuous efforts been made to attract global capital and technology. Where our partners have offered reasonable terms and met our national interests, bargains have been struck often at remarkable speed. There is a much sounder appreciation of the complexity of the global economy, especially of its intricate supply chains. And the internationalism of outlook has been demonstrated convincingly, whether it is the Vaccine Maitri, first responder operations or expanded development partnerships.

If India's diplomacy appears more nimble and creative now, much of the credit should go to a leader who has consciously striven to make it more contemporary and responsive. The whole 'Neighbourhood First' thinking developed from the 2014 swearing-in ceremony and his personal experiences. This idea of a non-reciprocal and generous policy took time for a bureaucracy to absorb, but it did finally get through. The Security and Growth for All in the Region (SAGAR) outlook was an effort to break long-standing silos even within the foreign ministry. When it came to the Gulf, there were decades of lazy assumptions in India about their lack of interest that had to be overcome. With Israel and Palestine, we have ended practising a hyphenation that we resented when applied to us. Moreover, India also made a distinction between its position on the need for a Palestinian state and its clear-cut condemnation of terrorism. The focus on opening new embassies in Africa and engaging more deeply was putting into practice what had been preached for long. As for the Pacific, till 2014, it was really beyond our horizons. The aggregate of all these changes, when stitched together with a cohesive global analysis, presents a very different picture.

While implementing policy is a daily chore, there are decisions taken from time to time that represent inflection points in the rise of a nation. India naturally has been subjected to its own set of tests and challenges on this score. And it has been the decisions taken under difficult circumstances that have become the hallmark of difference. A significant one was the decision even in the midst of the Covid lockdown to mobilize and deploy